

MANU MANIA GRIPS PARIS

IT TOOK SUSHIL KUMAR AND P. V. SINDHU — TWO OF INDIA'S GREATEST SPORTSPERSONS — FOUR YEARS TO WIN A SECOND INDIVIDUAL OLYMPIC MEDAL. NOW, **IN THE SPACE OF THREE DAYS**, MANU HAS WON TWO OF HER OWN.

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It's probably fair to say that even a week ago, most Indians would not have heard (let alone pronounced it correctly: it's Chateau + houh) of Chateauroux — the location of the shooting competition for the Paris Olympics. For the record, the town of 70,000 is located some 300 kilometres south of Paris, almost three hours by train from the French capital, in the heart of the Gaelic countryside.

Now it will be an inseparable pilgrimage site on the map of Indian sporting lore.

Chateauroux gets its name from the 11th-century castle (Chateau) of Raoul, the prince of Deols. But there's a new queen in town now. Her name is Manu Bhaker.

It's in Chateauroux that the 22-year-old wrote her name into the history books by accomplishing one of India's greatest sporting achievements.

It's hard to do justice to the magnitude of what pistol shooter Manu has accomplished here. Let's try to put it in perspective. It took 40 years for India to go from one individual medal (through KD Jadhav) to a second one (through Leander Paes). It took Sushil Kumar and P.V. Sindhu — two of India's greatest sportspersons — four years to win a second individual medal. Now, in the space of three days, in this provincial French town, Manu has won two of her own.

She opened India's medal tally two days after the opening ceremony with a bronze medal in the women's 10m air pistol competition. Two days later, in partnership with Sarabjot Singh, she

won another bronze in the 10m air pistol mixed team event.

She's breathing rarefied air in India's sporting pantheon at this point. She could potentially be alone at the top. At the time of going to press, Manu had another event to go.

A shot in the arm

She's done more than enough already. Not just for herself or even for Indian shooting — a discipline that had nothing to show for the efforts at the Olympics for 12 years — but for Indian sport. Her shots fired in Chateauroux have sounded all the way in Paris, where the rest of the Indian contingent is competing. She has ignited India's Olympic campaign — perennially diffident and underconfident — with energy, action, and, more importantly, belief.

"It has given a lot of boost to the whole contingent. Before we came